The search concentrated on Hebron, just down the road from the hitching post where the boys were abducted. Military correspondents embedded with the troops carrying out night raids there, and produced sensational stories with headlines like “a night in the city of terror”.[13] But the arrests were not confined to the southern West Bank. Soldiers raided homes as far north as Nablus and Jenin, and even downtown Ramallah, where an overnight operation set off some of the worst clashes there since the Second Intifada. Some Israeli politicians thought Netanyahu didn’t go far enough, however. Danny Danon, the deputy defense minister, proposed shutting off the electricity across the West Bank (which relies mostly on Israeli power plants).

All of this might have been justified, had it been possible that the teenagers were still alive. Yet the assumption was false. The security services had understood from the very beginning that they were probably dead. In a recording of Shaer’s last phone call, he could be heard whispering “they kidnapped me,” followed by what sounded like silenced gunshots—and then total silence.[14] Police had initially dismissed the call as a prank, and did not start investigating until hours later, when the boys’ parents reported them missing. Soldiers searching the area had quickly located the torched remains of the Hyundai; inside they found blood, shell casings, and eight bullet holes.

Local journalists were barred from reporting these details, however, because of a gag order issued by the prime minister’s office, a common practice on security-related stories in Israel. A few tried to push the envelope: Amos Harel, for example, made it clear in a 13 June piece for *Ha’aretz* that the teens were unlikely to be rescued.[15]

> One thing should be stated with care: As the hours go by, the chances of this affair ending well are diminishing… [in the West Bank], in most cases, they murder their hostages a short time after kidnapping them; they assume a live hostage leaves behind a greater “intelligence footprint” than a discarded body. A hostage needs to be guarded, fed, held and hidden—all actions that leave traces behind and can send security forces running to the rescue.

But much of the Israeli press swallowed the official spin. They were egged on by the army spokesman, Gen Moti Almoz, who held regular briefings on the search, and promoted the incorrect belief that the teenagers were alive. Politicians were in on the act, too: Lapid said in an interview that the emergency call was “impossible to decipher”, a claim that was quickly proved false once the recording was made public.